

Faculty Onboarding & Teaching Resource Guide

Supporting English-Medium Instruction at an International University

Original development: 2019 | Portfolio edition: 2026

PROJECT SUMMARY

A faculty-facing orientation and teaching resource designed to help instructors prepare for English-medium classes at Sun Yat-sen University. The original guide combined institutional context, implementation guidance, classroom strategies, language-skill activities, and locally relevant resources in one practical reference.

PROJECT AT A GLANCE

AUDIENCE	Instructors preparing to teach university courses in English.
NEED	Quick orientation to the teaching context plus practical, just-in-time support.
DELIVERABLE	A 17-page teaching resource guide, reframed here as an instructional-design case study and performance-support sample.
MY ROLE	Lead writer, organizer, and curator; synthesized classroom experience with contributions from faculty colleagues and students.
DESIGN FOCUS	Audience analysis, information architecture, faculty onboarding, scaffolding, activity design, resource curation, and implementation support.

PORTFOLIO PURPOSE

This edition demonstrates how the original content can be redesigned for clarity, scanability, accessibility, and workplace use while preserving the project's authentic scope and constraints.

CASE STUDY 01

The Performance Problem

The project began with a practical transition problem: capable instructors could arrive with subject expertise but little context for how English-medium teaching operated at the institution.

What instructors needed

- A concise orientation to the institutional and classroom environment.
- Realistic expectations for participation, language demands, and class routines.
- Strategies that could be used immediately in large or mixed-proficiency classes.
- A single place to find teaching activities and locally relevant resources.

What the guide needed to do

- Reduce uncertainty before the first class.
- Translate contextual knowledge into observable teaching actions.
- Support both pre-arrival preparation and in-the-moment reference.
- Respect variation among learners rather than treating observed patterns as universal.

CONTEXT & CONSTRAINTS

Design conditions

Varied experience: The audience could include new and experienced instructors with different levels of familiarity with the local context.

Technology variability: Classroom tools, connectivity, and access to online resources could differ by location and time.

Time pressure: Users needed answers quickly, often while planning or teaching.

Collaborative knowledge: Useful guidance came from lived experience and contributions by faculty and students, not from one author alone.

EVIDENCE BASE

The original project drew on the author's classroom experience, institutional context, and contributions from colleagues and students. It did not include a formal needs-analysis study, controlled usability test, or measured learning outcomes; this portfolio edition therefore avoids claims that exceed the available evidence.

CASE STUDY 02

Design Approach & Information Architecture

The central design move was to convert scattered contextual knowledge into a usable pathway: orient the instructor, anticipate common teaching decisions, and provide actions that can be applied quickly.

WORKFLOW

- 1. Clarify the audience and recurring questions** Identify what a newly arrived instructor would need before class, during planning, and while facilitating learning.
- 2. Group content by performance need** Separate institutional orientation from participation, scaffolding, language-skill practice, and resource selection.
- 3. Translate advice into action** Use examples, routines, activity steps, and prompts instead of relying on explanatory prose alone.
- 4. Support more than one use moment** Design for initial onboarding and later just-in-time reference.
- 5. Review, update, and localize** Treat links, platform guidance, and context statements as maintainable content requiring periodic review.

CONTENT ARCHITECTURE

ORIENT	Institution, campuses, classrooms, course formats, and first-week expectations
ANTICIPATE	Likely questions, participation barriers, language demands, and support needs
FACILITATE	Group work, routines, examples, scaffolds, projects, and presentations
PRACTICE	Speaking, listening, reading, and writing activities
EXTEND	Digital tools, resource curation, guide maintenance, and contribution pathways

Portfolio interpretation: the original work can be described through an ADDIE-informed lens, but it was not documented as a formal ADDIE project.

JOB AID SAMPLE 01

First-Weeks Quick Start

Portfolio reconstruction: this sample converts orientation content and teaching recommendations from the original guide into a scannable checklist for pre-class and first-week decisions.

Before the first class

- Confirm the campus, room, enrollment, meeting pattern, and available technology.
- Identify the approved communication channel and how students access course materials.
- Prepare a low-technology backup for any essential activity.
- Write one clear purpose statement for the course and the first class meeting.
- Plan a brief diagnostic task that reveals prior knowledge or language-support needs.

During the first class

- Explain how participation will work and why it supports learning.
- Model one routine students will use repeatedly.
- Give thinking or writing time before asking for public responses.
- Check directions by asking learners to restate the task or demonstrate the first step.
- Collect one piece of evidence that will inform the next lesson.

BEFORE THE FIRST MAJOR ASSIGNMENT

Assignment launch check

Outcome: State what successful performance looks like in learner-friendly language.

Criteria: Unpack the rubric or standards and connect each criterion to a visible feature.

Models: Use more than one varied example and discuss why each choice works.

Milestones: Break the work into proposal, planning, draft, feedback, revision, and submission stages as appropriate.

Support: Decide which scaffolds are temporary and when they will be reduced.

Feedback: Plan how learners will use feedback, not only how feedback will be delivered.

SUCCESS INDICATOR

An instructor can locate the next action in seconds, and a learner can explain the purpose, process, and quality criteria before beginning the task.

Participation & Group Work Protocol

This protocol reframes participation as a designed sequence rather than a personality trait. It gives learners time to prepare, makes roles visible, and lowers the language risk of responding in public.

FIVE-STEP FACILITATION ROUTINE

- 1. Think and write** Give learners quiet time to interpret the question and record an initial response.
- 2. Rehearse with a partner** Let learners test language and ideas before sharing with a larger group.
- 3. Assign useful roles** Use roles such as facilitator, evidence finder, language checker, recorder, or reporter.
- 4. Offer reporting options** Invite a spokesperson, shared document, visual, or brief written response when the learning goal allows.
- 5. Close the loop** Synthesize patterns, correct key misconceptions, and explain how the contribution advances the lesson.

Facilitator language	Evidence to observe
Prepare: “Take one minute to write one claim and one piece of evidence.” Rehearse: “Explain your idea to a partner before the group decides.” Clarify: “What evidence supports that choice?” Reflect: “Which part of the discussion changed or strengthened your thinking?”	• More learners contribute before whole-group reporting. • Group roles produce distinct, useful actions rather than labels only. • Responses include reasons, examples, or evidence. • Learners can explain the group’s decision and remaining questions.

DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Observed patterns in one teaching context should inform planning questions—not become universal claims about a culture, language group, or individual learner.

Scaffolding Without Creating Dependence

The goal of a scaffold is to make a difficult performance possible now while preparing the learner to complete it with less support later.

THE SCAFFOLD LADDER

1	Clarify	Name the outcome, audience, purpose, and quality criteria.
2	Deconstruct	Break the performance into visible decisions or steps.
3	Model thinking	Demonstrate the decision process, not only the finished product.
4	Compare examples	Use varied examples so learners analyze features instead of copying one answer.
5	Guide practice	Provide prompts, frames, checklists, or partial completion for early attempts.
6	Fade support	Remove prompts as performance becomes more accurate and independent.
7	Transfer	Ask learners to apply the strategy in a new context and explain their choices.
Use more support when... • The task is new or combines several unfamiliar skills. • Learners cannot yet explain the quality criteria. • Errors show a missing process, not just missing effort.		Fade support when... • Learners can select and use the strategy without prompting. • The scaffold begins to limit productive decision-making. • Independent performance is needed to assess transfer.
Model-use caution A complete model can become an answer to imitate. Use multiple examples, annotate the decisions behind them, and require learners to justify choices in their own context.		

JOB AID SAMPLE 04

Skill-Based Activity Cards

These abbreviated cards preserve the practical spirit of the original guide while making purpose, setup, steps, and evidence easier to scan.

SPEAKING**Minimal-Pair Notice & Produce**

Purpose: Distinguish and produce a targeted sound contrast.

Steps: Listen and sort; compare mouth position; practice in words and short phrases; record a final attempt.

Evidence: Learner identifies the contrast and produces it intelligibly in context.

LISTENING**Record, Compare & Repair**

Purpose: Connect pronunciation choices to listening comprehension.

Steps: Record a short text; compare with a model; mark omitted or altered sounds; rerecord with one improvement goal.

Evidence: Learner names the mismatch and applies a specific repair.

READING**Exchange, Annotate & Reconstruct**

Purpose: Notice meaning and form through peer-generated text.

Steps: Exchange short readings; annotate a target feature; discuss interpretations; revise the original based on useful feedback.

Evidence: Annotations connect textual evidence to an explanation.

WRITING**Workshop with a Phrase Bank**

Purpose: Use discipline-appropriate rhetorical moves in a draft.

Steps: Identify the move; study phrase options; draft; receive focused peer feedback; revise and explain one change.

Evidence: The phrase serves the writer's purpose and is adapted rather than copied mechanically.

ACTIVITY SELECTION CHECK

Align the activity

- What observable performance does the activity rehearse?
- Does the difficulty come from the target skill rather than unclear directions?
- What evidence will show whether another attempt is needed?

Prepare the conditions

- What model, prompt, or vocabulary support is necessary?
- Can every learner participate with the available time and technology?
- How will feedback lead to revision, replay, or transfer?

CASE STUDY 03

Evaluation, Reflection & Next Iteration

This edition treats the guide as a living performance-support product. Its value depends not only on content accuracy but also on findability, maintainability, accessibility, and evidence that instructors can use it effectively.

What this artifact demonstrates • Audience-centered faculty onboarding and implementation support. • Information architecture for a multi-topic resource. • Translation of experience into routines, checklists, and activity steps. • Cross-cultural communication framed with appropriate caution and specificity. • Resource curation and content-governance awareness.	Known limitations • No formal needs-analysis dataset or baseline performance measure. • No documented usability protocol or measured instructor outcomes. • Some original links, platforms, and technology guidance are now dated. • Institution-specific claims require current subject-matter review before reuse. • The original guide was visually dense and not developed to current accessibility standards.
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RECOMMENDED NEXT ITERATION

- 1. Validate the need** Interview new and experienced instructors; prioritize the decisions that create the greatest startup friction.
- 2. Prototype the delivery** Build a short onboarding pathway plus downloadable job aids rather than one long handbook.
- 3. Audit content** Verify institutional details, remove obsolete links, and assign owners and review dates.
- 4. Design for access** Apply heading structure, readable contrast, alt text, plain language, and WCAG-informed document practices.
- 5. Evaluate use** Track findability, completion of priority onboarding tasks, instructor confidence, and examples of classroom application.

Authorship & source note The 2019 source identifies Christopher M. Palasz as the person who created, organized, and compiled the guide and also acknowledges substantial contributions from faculty colleagues and students. This portfolio edition preserves that collaborative attribution. Institutional marks, personal contact information, contributor names, and dated external links have been intentionally omitted.

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